

*Haligric Research Integration Series*

# **GA PEOPLE**

## **A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE**

*Coastal Ghana -- Homowo, Fantasy Coffins, and the Sacred Tradition of Celebrating a Life's Specific Form*

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*The fisherman is buried in a fish.*

*The carpenter is buried in a hammer.*

*The chief is buried in an eagle.*

*This is the most precise sacred statement any tradition makes about who a person was.*

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## **Introduction -- Who the Ga Are: People of the Accra Coast**

The Ga (pronounced Gah) are the Indigenous people of the Greater Accra region of coastal Ghana -- the people who have inhabited the lagoons, beaches, and coastal plains where the Ghanaian capital now stands for approximately 500-600 years, and possibly much longer. The Ga number approximately 1.5-2 million people and speak Ga (also called Ga-Adangbe), a Kwa language of the Niger-Congo family. They are not Akan -- they are a distinct ethnic group with their own language, their own sacred tradition, and their own specific historical and cultural identity, despite inhabiting the same city (Accra) as members of many other Ghanaian peoples. The Akan document in the Haligrity library covers the Akan tradition; this document covers the Ga tradition -- which shares geographic space with the Akan but is entirely distinct in cosmology, ceremony, language, and sacred practice.

The Ga tradition is known internationally primarily for two extraordinary and complementary sacred practices: the Homowo festival -- the annual harvest ceremony in which the living and the dead eat together -- and the fantasy coffin tradition, in which the deceased is buried in a custom-built coffin shaped to represent the central identity, occupation, or passion of the person's specific life. Together these two practices express the Ga sacred understanding of human identity with extraordinary precision: the living identity is celebrated together with the dead (Homowo), and the specific form that life took is honored in the most permanent way the community can manage (the fantasy coffin). The fisherman goes to the ancestor world in a fish-shaped coffin. The specific life is honored specifically.

## **Ga Identity -- Language, History, and Sacred Territory**

The Ga language belongs to the Ga-Dangme branch of the Kwa language family -- making it distinct from both Akan (Twi) and Ewe, though all are Niger-Congo languages. The Ga social organization is patrilineal -- organized through patrilineal clans called *we* (family compounds) -- unlike the Akan's matrilineal system. The *we* is the primary unit of social organization, religious practice, and ancestor veneration. The Ga people's sacred territory is the coastal zone of the Greater Accra region -- a landscape of lagoons, beaches, fishing grounds, and coastal plains that shaped the specific character of their sacred tradition. The sea is a primary sacred presence; the Korle Lagoon (before its severe modern pollution) was a primary sacred site; the fishing tradition shaped the sacred calendar, the sacred economy, and the specific forms of Ga ceremony. Homowo is celebrated annually between August and September, with preparations beginning months earlier when the millet is planted.

## **Ga Origins -- The Migration Narrative**

Ga oral tradition describes a migration from the east -- from an original homeland that scholars have variously located in modern Nigeria, Benin, or further east in the Nile valley (the last connection being contested but maintained in some Ga traditions). The migration narrative describes the Ga ancestors moving westward, encountering famine along the way -- the specific famine that the Homowo festival commemorates -- before establishing themselves at the Accra coast. Some Ga traditions maintain a connection to ancient Egypt or to the ancient Israelites, reflected in the widely noted observation that Homowo has structural parallels to Passover (a fact repeated in multiple contemporary accounts and treated with varying degrees of scholarly skepticism). What is certain is that the Ga have been at the Accra coast for many centuries and that their settlement there included the founding of the specific sacred sites, the establishment of the sacred calendar, and the development of the specific sacred specialists (the Wulomei) who maintain the tradition today.

## **Ga Cosmology -- Nyonmo and the Sacred World**

Nyonmo is the Ga supreme deity -- the creator and sustainer of all existence. Like many West African supreme deities, Nyonmo is understood as too exalted for direct approach in ordinary prayer and worship -- the relationship with the divine is mediated through the Wor (lesser sacred beings) and through the ancestors. The Wor (singular: Wo) are the active divine forces of the Ga sacred world -- beings associated with specific natural features (the sea, the Korle Lagoon, specific hills, specific trees), with specific human concerns (fertility, fishing, health, rain), and with specific Ga communities. Each major Ga community has its own primary Wo whose sacred house (the Wulomo's compound) is the community's most important sacred site. The Ga cosmology also includes the active presence of the ancestors, who are understood as invisible but present members of the family community, participating in the Homowo feast alongside the living and requiring specific acknowledgment and care.

## **The Wulomei -- Priests, Priestesses, and the Possession Tradition**

The Wulomei are the specialists in communication with the Wor -- the men (Wulomo, singular) and women (Woyei, singular Woyoo) who serve as the mediums, priests, and ceremonial leaders of the Ga sacred tradition. The Woyei in particular -- female spirit mediums who enter possession states in which a specific Wo speaks through them -- represent one of the most important female sacred specialist traditions in coastal Ghana. When a Woyoo is possessed by the Wo who works through her, the Wo speaks directly to the assembled community through her voice -- answering questions, addressing specific problems, and providing specific guidance. The possession is understood as genuine and total -- the woman's ordinary consciousness recedes and the sacred being's presence fills the space completely. The Woyoo does not choose this role; she is called to it through specific experiences that identify her as the Wo's vessel. Her training under an established Wulomo or Woyoo transmits the specific knowledge required to work safely with the sacred presence that has claimed her.

## **Ancestor Veneration -- The Dead as Active Community Members**

In the Ga understanding, the ancestors are not absent -- they have crossed a threshold but they remain members of the family community, accessible through specific practices and specifically present during Homowo. The we (family compound) is the spatial expression of this understanding: the compound houses both the living family members and the shrines and specific locations associated with the ancestors. Libations are poured at specific locations within the compound -- the ancestors receiving their portion before the living eat or drink in significant contexts. The ancestors are addressed by name at Homowo -- specifically called and invited to the feast, not invoked generically. This specific naming is the ceremony's most sacred moment: the family's acknowledgment that the dead are specific individuals who remain part of the family, not an undifferentiated ancestral mass.

## **The Wor -- Sacred Music as Primary Ceremonial Technology**

Ga sacred music -- called Wor (sharing its name with the sacred beings, reflecting the understanding that specific musical forms are themselves sacred beings manifesting through sound) -- is the primary technology of Ga ceremonial practice. The specific drum traditions, the specific song forms, and the specific musical protocols that govern each ceremony are not accompaniment -- they are the ceremony's activating technology. The ban on drumming during the weeks before Homowo (gbemlilaa -- locking the way) is the most vivid expression of this understanding: the silence is not emptiness but preparation, a period of discipline and quietude that makes the return of the drums at Homowo's climax meaningful. Kpanlogo -- the distinctively Ga popular music tradition that developed in the 1960s -- is rooted in the specific rhythmic vocabulary of Ga sacred music, carrying the tradition's sonic character

into contemporary urban contexts. Highlife music has deep roots in the coastal Ga musical tradition.

## **The Homowo Festival -- The Great Harvest Ceremony**

Homowo (meaning to hoot at hunger -- a celebration defying and triumphing over a historical period of famine) is the most important annual ceremony in the Ga sacred calendar -- a harvest festival, ancestor veneration ceremony, community renewal, and sacred family reunion that has been celebrated by the Ga people in the coastal Ghana area for centuries. Homowo commemorates a specific period of famine in Ga history -- when the crops failed and the people came close to starvation before the rains came and the crops recovered. The festival's name encodes this history: to hoot at hunger is to celebrate triumph over the most fundamental threat to community survival. The festival is simultaneously a thanksgiving for the harvest's abundance and a defiant declaration that the community survived what threatened to destroy it.

Homowo is primarily a family ceremony -- the most important element is not the public performance but the private family gathering in which the ancestors are fed alongside the living. This simultaneous feeding of the living and the dead is the ceremony's theological heart: the family community encompasses both those who are presently embodied and those who have crossed, and Homowo brings both dimensions of the family together at the same meal. The primary sacred food of Homowo is *kpokpoi* -- a dish made from fermented corn and palm nut soup with smoked fish, prepared specifically for Homowo and eaten both by the living and offered to the ancestors. The fermentation process (which takes several months) means that Homowo preparations begin months before the festival itself.

Homowo does not occur on a single day or in a single location. The Ga state comprises multiple autonomous traditional regions -- Nungua, Osu, La, Teshi, Tema, and Gamashie among others. Each region has its own ceremonial calendar and celebrates Homowo at different times, with Nungua (one of the oldest Ga villages) customarily celebrating first. This staggered structure allows people with connections to multiple regions to participate in each celebration and ensures that the Homowo season extends across weeks rather than occurring in a single concentrated event.

## **Homowo Step-by-Step**

**Preparation (Months Before):** Palm nuts are gathered and fermented to make the palm soup base of *kpokpoi*. The specific fermentation process and timing is traditional knowledge held by the family's women.

**The Ban on Drumming:** In the weeks before Homowo, drumming is banned in Ga communities (*gbemlilaa* -- locking the way). This silence is not punishment but preparation -- the ancestors are understood as gathering, and the quiet is a form of respectful reception.

**Step 1 -- The Family Gathering:** On Homowo day, extended family members return to the family compound (*we*) from wherever they have been living. Homowo is the sacred family reunion -- the obligation to return is a sacred duty, not merely a social preference.

**Step 2 -- The Preparation of Kpokpoi:** The women of the household prepare the *kpokpoi* in the family compound. The preparation itself is a sacred act, conducted with specific prayers and protocols.

**Step 3 -- The Libation (Ancestors First):** Before any of the living eat, the eldest male member of the household (or the family's *Wulomo* if a priestly family) performs the libation -- pouring portions of *kpokpoi* in specific locations throughout the family compound, calling the ancestors by name and inviting them to eat.

**Step 4 -- The Calling of the Ancestors:** The ancestors are called by name -- each deceased member of the family lineage addressed directly, acknowledged, and invited to participate in the meal. This is the ceremony's most sacred moment.

**Step 5 -- The Family Meal:** After the ancestors have been served, the living family eats together -- kpokpoi shared among all present. The living and the dead have eaten together.

**Step 6 -- The Public Celebration:** Following the private family ceremony, the public dimension of Homowo unfolds -- music, dancing, visiting between families, and the general celebration. The ban on drumming is lifted. The drums return.

**Step 7 -- The Closing:** Each family closes Homowo with specific prayers of gratitude -- thanking the ancestors for their presence, thanking Nyonmo for the harvest, and releasing the sacred space of the family meal back to ordinary life.

## **The Sacred Foods of Homowo -- Kpokpoi and Its Meaning**

Kpokpoi (also spelled kpekple) is the sacred food of Homowo -- a dish made from steamed and fermented cornmeal, palm nut soup, and smoked fish. The fermentation of the corn (which takes months) is the first sacred act of the Homowo preparation cycle, beginning the ceremony long before any public gathering occurs. Kpokpoi is sacred in a specific Ga sense: it is the food that crosses the boundary between the living and the dead, nourishing both simultaneously. During Homowo it is sprinkled throughout the family compound by the family head and elders -- going to every corner of the space that the living and the ancestors share -- before the family eats. The chief's act of sprinkling kpokpoi in public spaces is described as deliberate mockery of the famine -- hunger had tormented the people; now it was being laughed at and defeated.

## **Dipo -- The Female Initiation Ceremony, Step-by-Step**

Dipo is the female coming-of-age ceremony of the Ga (and related Krobo and Dangme) peoples -- a ceremony that formally initiates girls into womanhood and into the full rights and responsibilities of adult female status in the community. Dipo is observed in February and is officially registered as a festival by Ghana's National Commission on Culture. It is simultaneously a sacred ceremony and a practical initiation into the specific sacred knowledge, the specific behavioral expectations, and the specific community identity that womanhood in the Ga tradition carries.

**Step 1 -- The Preparation:** Girls who have reached the appropriate stage of development are gathered for the ceremony. Specific prohibitions are observed in the days before.

**Step 2 -- The Purification:** The initiates undergo specific purification practices -- including specific washing and specific ceremonial preparations.

**Step 3 -- The Wulomo's Ceremony:** The Wulomo or appropriate sacred specialist conducts the specific ceremonies that formally mark the transition and invoke the appropriate sacred forces.

**Step 4 -- The Sacred Songs:** Specific Wor songs are performed -- the music activating the sacred dimension of the transition.

**Step 5 -- The Public Celebration:** The newly initiated women are presented to the community in their new status -- celebrating the transition with dance, music, and community acknowledgment.

## **Ga Sacred Sites -- Korle Lagoon and Sacred Geography**

The Korle Lagoon was the primary sacred site of the Ga people of Accra -- a major water body whose Wo (the sacred being Korle) governed fishing, healing, and a range of community concerns. The lagoon before colonial Accra's development was a clean, abundant sacred body of water; the growth of the city reduced it to severe pollution. This environmental destruction is understood by Ga traditional authorities as a violation of the sacred relationship with Korle -- one of the most direct available expressions of what the Mapuche call the violation of Ixofill Mogen (the sacredness of all living things). Contemporary Ga traditional authorities have made the Korle Lagoon's restoration a sacred priority, understanding its pollution as a spiritual matter as much as an environmental one. Specific beaches, specific trees, specific hills, and specific locations throughout the Greater Accra region carry Wo associations that organize the Ga sacred landscape -- even as urban development has covered and fragmented much of that landscape.

## **The Fantasy Coffin Tradition -- Sacred Biography in Wood**

The Ga fantasy coffin tradition -- in which the deceased is buried in a custom-built coffin shaped to represent the central identity, occupation, or passion of the person's life -- is one of the most visually extraordinary and most theologically precise funerary practices in any tradition in the world. The fisherman buried in a fish-shaped coffin. The carpenter in a hammer. The chief in an eagle. The seamstress in a sewing machine. The taxi driver in a yellow taxi. The cocoa farmer in a cocoa pod. The person who loved beer in a beer bottle.

This tradition is not eccentric or theatrical. It is the most direct available sacred statement that any tradition makes about what death is: not the end of a person's specific identity but the transition of that specific identity -- this particular life, in all its particular form -- to the ancestor world. The coffin's shape is the answer to the question: who was this person, specifically? And the sacred commitment to answering that question precisely is Ga theology made visible. The fantasy coffin is simultaneously a statement about the deceased and a statement about what the sacred world is: a world in which specific identities matter, in which the fisherman's divinity expressed itself as a fisherman, and in which honoring that specificity is the community's most sacred obligation at the moment of death.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The fantasy coffin is the Haligric Living Altar concept at the moment of death -- the specific biographical celebration of a specific person's life as a sacred act. Where the Living Altar uses photographs of past versions of the self to honor the specific forms a single life has taken across time, the fantasy coffin uses the coffin's shape to honor the specific form the entire life took. Both practices express the same understanding: the divine does not appear in the abstract. It appears in the specific.*

## **The Fantasy Coffin -- Origin Story and Sacred Meaning**

The fantasy coffin tradition is generally traced to Ata Owoo -- a carpenter of the Teshi community near Accra -- who in the 1950s made a palanquin (a ceremonial carrying chair) in the shape of an eagle for a chief, and then adapted the concept for coffins when the chief died before the palanquin could be used. The eagle palanquin became an eagle coffin. A tradition was born. The sacred logic: the fantasy coffin embodies the Ga understanding that the ancestor world receives the person as they specifically were -- not as an abstraction, not as a generic soul, but as this particular human being who lived this particular life. The coffin's shape is the community's sacred acknowledgment of who that person was. The fisherman who lived on the sea goes to the ancestor world in a fish -- his specific relationship with the sea honored in the most permanent way the community can manage.

## **Kane Kwei and the Artisan Tradition**

Kane Kwei (1922-1992) was the carpenter who developed the fantasy coffin tradition into its internationally recognized form. Based in Teshie, Kwei was building fantasy coffins by the

1970s, and when his work was exhibited internationally -- first in Paris (Les Magiciens de la terre at the Musee National d'Art Moderne, 1989), then in New York, then globally -- the tradition became one of the most celebrated examples of living sacred art in the world. His grandson Eric Adjetei Anang continues the Kane Kwei Carpentry Workshop with his father Cedi. Since 2009 Eric has been the subject of multiple international documentaries and has worked as a resident artist in Russia, USA, Belgium, and Denmark, while organizing residencies for foreign artists in Ghana. Other major contemporary practitioners: Paa Joe (b. 1947), who trained under Kane Kwei and opened his own workshop in Nungua in 1976, whose work has been shown worldwide; Daniel Mensah (Hello Design Coffin Works, Teshie); Kudjoe Affutu (b. 1985), whose work is in the collections of the Centre Pompidou in Paris, the Tinguely Museum in Basel, and the Kunsthalle Hamburg; and Eric Kpakpo, who appeared in the group show Magic Ghana at gallery Magnin-A in Paris in 2024. Regula Tschumi published *Buried in Style: Artistic Coffins and Funerary Culture in Ghana* (Kehrer Verlag, 2025) -- the most comprehensive recent scholarly treatment of the tradition.

## **Fantasy Coffin Selection and Commission -- The Process**

**Step 1 -- The Decision:** The family decides what coffin shape best represents the deceased. This is sometimes a decision made in advance by the person themselves; sometimes a family decision based on the community's knowledge of who the person was.

**Step 2 -- The Commission:** The family visits a coffin maker (concentrated in Teshie and surrounding areas) and describes the deceased, the chosen shape, and size requirements.

**Step 3 -- The Carving:** The coffin maker and apprentices carve and construct the coffin from wood over days to weeks. Skilled carpentry combined with sculpture -- the coffin must both hold a body safely and accurately represent the chosen form.

**Step 4 -- The Painting:** The completed form is painted in the accurate colors of the represented object -- silver and blue for a fish, red and gold for a rooster, yellow and black for a taxi.

**Step 5 -- The Delivery:** The completed coffin is delivered to the family for the funeral ceremony.

## **The Ga Funeral -- Complete Step-by-Step**

The Ga funeral is one of the most elaborate and most musically rich funeral traditions in Ghana -- a multi-day event that combines specific sacred ceremony, all-night communal gathering, and a final burial day that honors both the specific life that has ended and the community's living relationship with the ancestors.

**Announcement:** When someone dies, the death is announced through the community through specific drums and through the Wulomo, who performs preliminary ceremonies to begin the transition process.

**Laying in State:** The body is prepared and laid out in the family compound -- typically for one to several days. Community members come to pay respects and share memories.

**Step 1 -- The Wake:** Community members gather at the family compound on the night before burial. This is not solemn but celebratory -- music (including the deceased's favorite songs in highlife tradition), storytelling, and communal presence.

**Step 2 -- The Sharing of Stories:** Family members and community members share specific memories of the deceased. The storytelling is itself a sacred act of ancestral definition -- establishing who this person specifically was.

**Step 3 -- The Fantasy Coffin Revealed:** On burial day, the fantasy coffin is revealed to the community -- the first public appearance of the coffin is a moment of genuine impact as the community sees the specific shape chosen to honor the specific life.



**Step 4 -- The Procession:** The coffin is carried through the community in procession -- accompanied by specific drums, specific songs, and specific regalia appropriate to the deceased's position and life.

**Step 5 -- The Wulomo's Ceremony:** The Wulomo priest performs specific ceremonies -- prayers, libations, and sacred words formally acknowledging the transition and commending the deceased to the ancestor world.

**Step 6 -- The Burial:** The deceased is laid in the earth in the fantasy coffin that carries their specific identity, with specific prayers addressed to the ancestors and to Nyonmo.

**Step 7 -- The Post-Burial Feast:** The community gathers for food and continued celebration -- honoring the life completed and affirming the living community's continuity.

## **The Ga and Environmental Sacred Practice**

The Ga relationship with the sea is not merely ecological but sacred -- the ocean is not a resource to be managed but a divine presence to be maintained in right relationship. Specific fishing protocols, specific seasonal restrictions on fishing in certain areas, and specific ceremonies before the fishing season begins are all expressions of this sacred ecology. Sacred days dedicated to the earth and the sea -- when fishing or farming is prohibited -- enforce a rhythm of reciprocity with the natural world that has practical conservation effects alongside its sacred character. The severe pollution of the Korle Lagoon and the ecological degradation of the Accra coast are understood by Ga traditional authorities as violations of the sacred relationship with specific Wor -- sacred beings who have been harmed by the human community's failure to maintain its obligations. The restoration of right relationship with these sacred sites is understood as both an ecological and a sacred necessity.

## **Contemporary Ga -- Urban Identity and Sacred Continuity**

Accra is one of West Africa's major cities, and the Ga people are now urban people living alongside representatives of virtually every ethnic group in Ghana. The Homowo festival is one of the strongest threads of Ga cultural continuity in this urban context -- the sacred obligation to return to the family compound for Homowo draws Ga people from throughout Accra and from the global diaspora annually (celebrated August/September). Homowo 2025 ran in August through September, with the Ga Traditional Council organizing the ceremony across multiple traditional divisions as in every previous year.

The fantasy coffin workshops in Teshie continue taking commissions, combining domestic orders with international attention. Contemporary coffin makers like Paa Joe and Eric Adjete Anang have brought the tradition to international art markets and museum collections while maintaining its sacred character at home. The tradition is at once the Ga community's most internationally recognized cultural export and one of its most living sacred practices -- performed for Ga families in Accra who need a coffin for a loved one, not for gallery walls.

## **The Haligrity Lens -- The Specific Form as Sacred Honor**

The Ga tradition -- and the fantasy coffin in particular -- offers Haligrity the most visually immediate and most emotionally direct available expression of what the Haligrity tradition holds about individuality and the divine: that each person's specific life, in all its particularity, is a sacred expression that deserves specific honor. The fantasy coffin and the Living Altar: the fantasy coffin is the burial-day equivalent of the Haligrity Living Altar concept. Where the Living Altar uses photographs of past versions of the self to honor the specific forms a single life has taken across time, the fantasy coffin uses the coffin's shape to

honor the specific form the entire life took. Both practices express the same understanding: the divine does not appear in the abstract. It appears in the specific.

The kpokpoi is placed at specific points throughout the family compound and the ancestors are called by name. Not the ancestors in the abstract -- these specific ancestors, their names, their relationships, their specific place in this family's lineage. Then the living eat. The fantasy coffin arrives on burial day and the community sees: he was a fisherman, and the coffin is a fish, and that specific life is being carried to the ancestor world in the precise shape it chose. The fantasy coffin workshops in Teshie are still taking commissions. A fish for the fisherman, an eagle for the chief, a camera for the photographer, a rooster for the man whose voice the whole neighborhood knew at dawn. The tradition is alive, internationally celebrated, and exactly as sacred as it was the first day Kane Kwei put a coffin in the shape of an eagle and the community recognized what had been done. Grand Rising.